Independence. As such, he made it quite clear that Singh was nothing short of a political prisoner and that the government needed to treat him as such and not just as a common criminal. With devastating effect, Jinnah said,

> Well, you know perfectly well that these men are determined to die. It is not a joke. I ask the honourable law member to realise that it is not everybody who can go on starving himself to death. Try it for a little while and you will see . . . The man who goes on hunger strike has a soul. He is moved by that soul and he believes in the justice of his cause; he is not an ordinary criminal who is guilty of cold-blooded, sordid, wicked crime. [2]

So impressive was Jinnah that, as he continued, oblivious of the time when the day's session for the assembly came to an abrupt end, a Hindutva stalwart who had once been a Congress Party president by the name of Madan Mohan Malaviya begged the speaker of the assembly saying, 'Sir, cannot we go on for another 15 minutes?' His earnest request was turned down as the time was up for the day. If Jinnah wished to continue his entreaties on behalf of Bhagat Singh, he had to return to the assembly the next day and continue. Jinnah had no compunction in doing so. The next day, in a withering critique, Jinnah also denounced the proposed new law by the Government as quite simply 'an absurd provision' in language that is worth setting out in full:

> It seems to me, Sir, that the great and fundamental doctrine of British jurisprudence, which is incorporated and codified in the Penal Code and the Criminal Procedure Code has very wisely not made such an absurd provision in the criminal law of this country and I am not satisfied that there is a lacuna in our system of criminal law. [3]

Despite this, Jinnah's contribution in the life of Bhagat Singh is almost entirely overlooked today. In his book *Jinnah and Tilak*, A.G. Noorani explains how the effect since Independence of 'state control of universities' and 'misdirected patriotism' [4] is that today more than half a century after Independence, '[m]any a myth deserves to be dispelled', as unlike other Congress leaders in India, '[n]one of the Liberals criticized the British as trenchantly as he did. None participated in mass politics. Jinnah's rhetoric reflected fierce patriotism'. [5] Later in his book, he describes how